

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Saturday, May 12, 2018, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 9:00 a.m.

Members of the Council present were:

At-Large Councilor Claire Lessard
Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone
Assistant Mayor Allen Damren
Mayor Charlene Lovett
At-Large Councilor Jeremy Zullo
At-Large Councilor Abigail Kier
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski
Ward II Councilor Scott Pope

Also present:

Ryan McNutt, City Manager
Mary Walter, Finance Director

AGENDA CHANGES

None

CITIZEN’S FORUM

None one spoke.

BUDGET

Mayor Lovett reviewed the process. Citizens will be allowed to comment at each budget for a limit of three minutes. She suggested Department Heads speak first and then Councilors can ask questions. She suggested Councilors focus on the macro instead of each line item.

Mayor Lovett asked Ms. Walter for the actuals, as they show the trends.

Assessing

Department Request \$495,974.64 City Manager Proposed \$495,313.00

There was a discussion about the revaluation. Mr. McNutt said the last one was completed in 2013. It’s usually on a five-year cycle. He said we currently have 25% of the revaluation done.

We will do the remaining 75% by 2019. We will review all categories. The revaluation company will go inside everyone's house.

Ms. Walter said going forward, we will work on a two-year cycle and that will help stabilize the values.

Mr. McNutt said the next revaluation will be in 2021 and that will be a statistical update. Ms. Walter said the last statistical update cost \$75,000-\$80,000.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Mr. Koloski and seconded by Mr. Damren to tentatively approve the Assessing budget for \$495,313.00.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Planning & Development

Department Request \$1,104,222.99 City Manager Proposed \$1,100,071.00

Nancy Merrill, Planning and Development Director, gave an overview of the department. She said there is \$25,000 in the budget to rebuild the City's website.

Ms. Merrill said there is \$100,000 for pre-engineering Pleasant Street revitalization. The project will include replacing water and sewer lines, new drainage systems, new sidewalks, street lights, traffic calming, parking, traffic flow behind buildings, etc. Over the last 5 years, there have been 10 public meetings on this. The first step is to hire an engineer then look for federal funding.

Mr. McNutt said a parking structure would cost about \$4.5 million. Ms. Merrill said the City is working with businesses regarding surface parking.

There was a discussion about grants. Ms. Merrill said all staff in her department are involved in grant writing. Last year they received \$1.1 million in grants.

Regarding business development and marketing, Ms. Merrill said there is a Made in Claremont marketing program going on. The City is marketing in upstate New York and Connecticut.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Ms. Kier to tentatively approve the Planning & Development budget for \$1,100,071.00.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

TIFD-Downtown

Department Request \$864,600 City Manager Proposed \$864,600

Ms. Walter said the TIFD-Downtown Revenues are projected to be slightly up. We're borrowing less from General Fund because debt is down.

Ms. Walter said the last bond payment will be in FY2028.

Regarding the increase in Electric – Parking Garage, Ms. Walter said we tried not having lights on as often, but people didn't feel safe and there was some drug use and homeless people hanging out.

Ms. Merrill said it is anticipated this item will drop this year because the 5-year Smart Start will end and then we will pay actual costs.

Mr. Koloski asked about changing where the lights are left on and he asked about adding solar. Ms. Merrill said when the LED conversion was done, the lights would dim and then when motion was detected, go brighter.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Mr. Zullo and seconded by Mr. Damren to tentatively approve the TIFD-Downtown budget for \$860,600 with a change to Electric – Parking Garage from \$32,000 to \$28,000 and Revenue Income from General Fund would be \$287,590 for Revenue Total of \$860,600.

Mr. Koloski said he will vote no on this tentative approval. He would like to look at correcting the lighting in the dark areas and adding solar.

Voice vote: motion carried 8-1 with Mr. Koloski voting no.

Water

Department Request \$2,190,600 City Manager Proposed \$2,197,013

Scott Sweet, Public Works Director, gave an overview of some of the projects his department has been working on including replacing water meters, back flushing filters, cleaning pipes from White Water Reservoir which decreases the amount of water being pulled from the Sugar River. Lead-lined water line replacements continue to be ongoing; there are over 70 left. They are going out to bid to replace a 2-inch water line on Ridge Avenue. Utility Partners was the only bidder for the Water/Wastewater Plant bids.

Mr. Sweet is working to identify unaccounted-for water usage. The plant is making 934,000 gallons/day and selling 600,000+/day.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. Zullo to tentatively approve the Water budget for \$2,197,013.00.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Sewer

Department Request \$2,731,666.00 City Manager Proposed \$2,739,776.00

Mr. Sweet gave a brief overview of some of the projects including work on the solar field will start at the end of May. He said the whole electrical system of the wastewater treatment plant will have to be replaced.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Mr. Koloski and seconded by Ms. Kier to tentatively approve the Sewer budget for \$2,739,776.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Sanitation (Transfer Station)

Department Request \$176,949.78 City Manager Proposed \$177,409.00

Mr. Sweet said there have not been a lot of changes. The “put & take” shack is hard to police. The two people who work there are busy. He would love to see volunteers work it.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Mr. Koloski and seconded by Ms. Kier to tentatively approve the Sanitation (Transfer Station) budget for \$177,409.00.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Cemetery

Department Request \$205,938.00 City Manager Proposed \$206,713.00

Mr. Sweet said there are not a lot of changes. He is getting the Main Street cemetery gates renovated. He encumbered some money last year for the gates. Norma Limoges is going out to ask for donations for the pillars.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. Stone to tentatively approve the Cemetery budget for \$206,713.00.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Streets & Roads (Highways)

Department Request \$2,949,071.00 City Manager Proposed \$2,699,408.00

Mr. Sweet said last year they paved Washington Street and Main Street with some state money. Washington Street still needs work and so do a lot of other roads. They have done a lot of drainage/catch basin work.

There was discussion about Vehicle Equipment M&R for two 6-wheelers. Mr. Zullo thinks it would be beneficial to look into having at least one of them be a 10-wheeler.

There was a discussion about the cost to preserve the paved roads that were done with the \$1.5 million road bond.

Mr. Sweet estimates the life expectancy is about 8 years without crack sealing, but with preservation, it could be double that.

Ms. Kier was concerned about sidewalks and said she thinks there is liability issue, so she wants to make sure that is funded correctly.

Mayor Lovett would like to know the cost to preserve the roads that were done with the \$1.5 million bond.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Ms. Lessard to tentatively approve the Streets & Roads (Highways) budget for \$2,699,408.00.

Voice vote: motion carried 8-1 with Ms. Kier voting no.

Police

Department Request \$2,809,306.00 City Manager Proposed \$2,742,784.00

Police Chief Mark Chase said he worked with the City Manager and the Finance Director on this budget and he feels he can work with it. He highlighted some areas of his department. He said over the last year, his biggest challenge has been personnel. Last year the department launched its Facebook page. The K-9 program has begun and Tyler Petrin is currently in K-9 training.

Chief Chase said locker rooms, break room, and dispatch window project bids are due at the end of the month.

There was a discussion about the cruiser fleet replacement. Chief Chase said there was a cruiser accident last year and the vehicle was totaled. The money from that and the K-9 grant will be used for the K-9 vehicle (paid outright). He expects that vehicle to last the length of the K-9 program (6-8 years). He is keeping one vehicle for the SRO officer as it has low mileage. He will ask to replace five cars. When the new vehicles arrive, dash cams will be installed. They are exploring body cams.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Mr. Pope and seconded by Ms. Kier to tentatively approve the Police budget for \$2,742,784.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Communications 911

Department Request \$521,178 City Manager Proposed \$525,437

Chief Chase said retention has been good. RFP to replace the dispatch window (ballistic) went out for bid. He will use encumbered money.

Chief Chase said in Rents & Leases there is \$1,000 for Copsync which is now defunct. Mayor Lovett asked if this budget can be reduced. Chief Chase said yes Copsynce is \$960.

Mayor Lovett said she is going try to do everything she can to move money to roads. She asked to reduce this budget by \$1,000.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Mr. Zullo and seconded by Mr. O’Hearne to tentatively approve the Communications 911 budget for \$524,437.00.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Fire

Department Request \$2,558,661.00 City Manager Proposed \$2,475,173.00

Fire Chief Bryan Burr said that he prefers to have five-person shifts. Staffing levels have gone up and down and currently they have four-person shifts. He is not happy with reduced staffing, but he doesn’t want to increase the budget. One person with benefits is \$78,632. Ms. Walter said that is 12 cents on the tax rate.

After discussion Mr. McNutt suggested looking into the duties of the fire alarm superintendent to see if it could be a contracted service.

Chief Burr said there 11 Call Firefighters on the roster. Mr. McNutt said at a recent trailer fire that only 2 Call Firefighters responded. Mr. Koloski said that daytime schedules don't always allow everyone to respond.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. Stone to tentatively approve the Fire budget for \$2,475,173.00.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Airport

Department Request \$124,904.00 City Manager Proposed \$124,904.00

Mr. McNutt said there is \$12,500 in Consulting Services for an airport consultant. The Fire Chief is a new chief and he would like to spend his time on Fire Department issues. Former Fire Chief Rick Bergeron has expressed interest in the position. Also, one of the individuals working at the airport is in his 90s and if necessary, the consultant position could take over those duties.

Mayor Lovett suggested raising revenue by businesses advertising at the airport.

Chief Bergeron said he spends a lot of the time working on the projects at the Airport. The Airport manager is required to test the fuel system weekly and to take delivery of the fuel when it arrives.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. Stone to tentatively approve the Airport budget for \$124,904.00.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Library

Department Request \$489,681 City Manager Proposed \$402,783

Mike Grace, Librarian, said very little has changed from the current budget. He is requesting four full-time people versus the three he has now. Everyone is stepping up to maintain services. Oftentimes there are fewer staff in the building than before.

Mr. Grace had requested \$500 for Microfilming/Digitization of Records, but that was not in the City Manager's Proposed budget. Ms. Kier said she would be in favor of putting that amount back in. Mr. Koloski said he has used those before. He agreed to adding \$500 each year.

When asked what the impact is behind the scenes, Mr. Grace said the stacks are not maintained as well, planning for additional services and changes in layout of the Library are more difficult to do. All staff is in front of the public all day except for the custodian.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Ms. Lessard and seconded by Mr. Damren to tentatively approve the Library budget for \$402,783.

A motion was made by Mr. Pope and seconded by Mr. Koloski to amend the dollar amount to \$403,283.

Voice vote on the amendment: motion carried 8-1 with Mayor Lovett voting no.

Voice vote to tentatively approve the Library budget for \$403,283: motion carried 8-1 with Mayor Lovett voting no.

Parks

Department Request \$402,982.25 City Manager Proposed \$402,713

Mark Brislin, Parks and Recreation Director, talked about some of the department's programs such as 10 parks with approximately 550 acres; Community Center with approximately 300 check-ins per day; sports and recreation programs; and special events such as July 4th. He said the Farmers Market has been added to this budget. The grant is enough to get it started and offsetting revenues are expected to be received. It is expected to be self-sustaining. Superintendent of Parks & Facilities is now split between the Community Center and Parks.

There was a discussion about the JSL (Junior Sports League) building. Ms. Walter said the City has gone out for RFP at least six times. Mr. McNutt said we have marketed the building and people have approached us about it, but we were not confident of their ability to follow through on their plans. He talked about looking at it for a regionalized dispatch building. Mr. Pope suggested this could be an agenda item for a future meeting. Mayor Lovett asked for an anticipated timeframe when a regional dispatch would get off the ground. Mr. Damren would like to have a decision whether to keep or demolish the building by the end of this Council term in 2019. He would like a presentation on the potential uses of the JSL building.

There was a discussion about Part Time and the request for \$15,285. Mr. Brislin said they have not been able to find a consistent person for the part-time position. Mayor Lovett said the most that has been spent is around \$10,000. She said there is no history to justify the additional \$5,000. She said she would make a motion to modify that amount.

Mr. Koloski asked for an overall snapshot of Arrowhead. They provide a great service to this community, but it is run by Chuck Allen, and other volunteers, and he would like to know the condition of the property if, and when, they no longer run it.

Mayor Lovett said Mr. Allen had said they are working on a strategic plan and a transition plan.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. Zullo to tentatively approve the Parks budget for \$397,713.00.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

CSB Community Center – Recreation

Department Request \$1,134,971.60 City Manager Proposed \$1,133,456.00

Mr. Brislin said they have over 300 check-ins per day at the Claremont Savings Bank Community Center (CSBCC). The greatest change was to the division of the Superintendent of Parks & Facilities position as stated above.

Mr. Damren said that Mr. Brislin runs a good operation there.

Regarding building maintenance, Mr. Brislin said the building sees a lot of use. They replaced the wall behind the basketball net and have replaced some pool tiles. There is a game plan for repairs for this year. The reconditioned HVAC will help with energy expenses. During the winter, the sidewalks are heated.

There was a discussion about parking and Mr. Brislin said the parking lot is typically full the first thing in the morning. It would be great to have more parking.

Mayor Lovett said Mr. Brislin has done a good job keeping hold of the expenses. She said he's done an excellent job.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Ms. Kier to tentatively approve the CSB Community Center – Recreation budget for \$1,133,456.00.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Welfare

Department Request \$386,033.40 City Manager Proposed \$371,747.00

Suzanne Carr, Welfare Director, said there is a bit of a decrease this year. She does not expect to come back to the Council this year to ask for more money.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Mr. O’Hearne and seconded by Mr. Damren to tentatively approve the Welfare budget for \$371,747.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Policy

Department Request \$614,552.64 City Manager Proposed \$615,025.00

Ms. Walter said the Human Resources position is being moved from the Finance budget to the Policy budget. She said attorneys typically charge \$185-\$400/hour and our maximum salary is \$44/hour. The Policy budget does not include legal, but it does include an “admin floater.” The ideal person would have some paralegal background in order to help draft legal documents, but not actually be working in a legal capacity. That position would also help Human Resources and Assessing with clerical needs.

Mayor Lovett said the Council wants to know what the total legal expenses are to know whether or not legal is being done as efficiently as possible.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Ms. Kier to tentatively approve the Policy budget for \$615,025.00.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Outside Agency Request

Department Request \$25,000.00 City Manager Proposed \$25,000.00

Ms. Walter said this is for the bus service and the money is coming from Fund Balance.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Ms. Kier and seconded by Mr. Damren to tentatively approve the Outside Agency Request budget for \$25,000.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

City Administration (Finance)

Department Request \$895,418.13 City Manager Proposed \$891,272.00

Ms. Walter said this budget is for Central Collections, Finance, Accounts Payable, Payroll and IT. Human Resources is being moved to the City Manager’s budget. The bottom line is down \$91,385.

Regarding the software upgrade. Ms. Walter said the current software is still supported. She expects an upgrade will be done after she retires in 3-5 years. By then, most of the money needed should be set aside (estimated \$600,000).

There was a question of keeping Central Collections open during lunchtime. Ms. Walter said there is a safety concern because of the number of staff that are available. Payments can be made online and there is a box in front of the door for payments. Mr. Koloski suggested putting a message on the door that payments can be made online.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Ms. Lessard and seconded by Mr. Damren to tentatively approve the City Administration (Finance) budget for \$891,272.00.

Voice vote: motion carried 8-1 with Mr. O’Hearne voting no.

Municipal Complex (Maintenance)

Department Request \$612,842.00 City Manager Proposed \$509,932.00

Ms. Walter said this is for maintenance of City Hall. There is one full-time and two part-time people. She said work on the dome will be done for \$50,000 instead of the \$780,000 originally estimated. There is \$75,000 in the budget for the flat roof. Also, there is money for an ADA compliant bathroom outside Central Collections.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Mr. Koloski and seconded by Mr. Zullo to tentatively approve the Municipal Complex (Maintenance) budget for \$509,932.00.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Elections

Department Request \$14,325.00 City Manager Proposed \$14,325.00

Ms. Walter said last year there was one election. This coming year there will be two elections.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Mr. Koloski and seconded by Ms. Kier to tentatively approve the Elections budget for \$14,325.000.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Debt Retirement (Debt Service)

Department Request \$1,170,069.00 City Manager Proposed \$1,170,069.00

Ms. Walter said there is no new debt. 2021 will be the last year for three loans and that will save us \$345,000 and that will become available in 2022.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Ms. Kier and seconded by Mr. Damren to tentatively approve the Debt Retirement (Debt Service) budget for \$1,170,069.00.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

General Services

Department Request \$1,416,754.00 City Manager Proposed \$1,248,654.00

Ms. Walter said the Loan (Transfer) to Downtown TIFD needs to be reduced to \$287,590 (\$4,000 reduction). She said General Services is for shared services. She said Overlay is for abatements and those would come fully from the City. County and School do not contribute to abatements.

Ms. Walter said \$500,000 is being taken from Fund Balance to help reduce the tax rate. Mr. McNutt said that is equal to 71cents on the tax rate.

Regarding Legal Services, Mayor Lovett would like to get a better handle on whether or not it was the right move to go from in-house Legal to outside Legal. She would like to know the cost difference between the two.

[Note: No public spoke.]

A motion was made by Mr. Zullo and seconded by Mr. Damren to tentatively approve the General Services budget for \$1,244,654.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Revenue

Department Request \$5,791,677.00 City Manager Proposed \$6,351,677.00

Ms. Walter said that Revenue will have to drop by \$4,000.

There was a discussion about the CDA (Claremont Development Authority) and the time Ms. Merrill has spent working on the elevator issue for the Farwell Block and the old Pleasant

Restaurant. Mr. Koloski thinks the CDA should pay for Ms. Merrill's time. Mr. McNutt said he will ask Ms. Merrill to provide a more in-depth response.

Mayor Lovett talked about increasing Revenues in order to reduce the proposed tax rate increase. Ms. Walter said the state may allow dealerships to register vehicles. She does not know what that impact will be. She expects in the future that the state will take this from the local level in order to keep that revenue. She would rather be conservative. If we don't match the proposed revenues, we cannot make it up.

[Note: No public spoke.]

After further discussion about revenues, Council made a motion to table the discussion.

A motion was made by Mr. Stone and seconded by Mr. Damren to table discussion of the Revenue until the next Budget meeting.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None

ADJOURNMENT

Mr. McNutt said the Finance Committee meets the first and third Tuesdays of the month.

There was a consensus of the Council to meet on May 31, 6:30 p.m.

Mr. Stone asked to schedule a non-meeting at 5:30 p.m. on May 23 to discuss Charter issues regarding personnel. He requested an attorney be physically present instead of over the phone.

At 4:53 p.m., a motion was made by Mr. Zullo and seconded by Mr. Damren to adjourn.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council